

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

# Why Do People Hurt People?

---

In late February, Darius came in mad.

He had been mad since the bus. He had been mad since before the bus. He had been mad since he woke up. He sat at his desk with his arms crossed and his eyebrows together and he did not say good morning to anybody.

Ms. Calloway, who had been teaching long enough to know that a six-year-old this mad is a six-year-old carrying something, did not ask him about it. She let him sit. She let him be mad.

At circle time, when Sammy came out, the lesson was about why people hurt people.

"Friends," said Sammy, "today we are going to ask one of the hardest questions in the whole world. Are you ready?"

The kids nodded. Most of them. Darius did not move.

"The question is — why do people hurt people? When somebody is mean to you, why are they being mean? Is it because they are bad? Is it because they hate you?"

The kids looked at Sammy.

"Here is the answer," said Sammy. "And it is a hard one to learn. Most of the time, when somebody hurts you, it is NOT because they hate you. It is NOT because they are bad. It is because they are carrying something heavy themselves."

"Remember the backpack? Everybody has a backpack. Everybody has stones. When somebody comes at you with

mean words, or unkind behavior, or a hurt — usually it is because their own backpack is so heavy that they are about to fall over. And when people are about to fall over, sometimes they push other people. Not because the other people did anything. Because they are trying not to fall."

Sammy paused.

"This is called understanding the why. It does not make what they did okay. What they did is still what they did. Naming the why is not the same as saying it is okay. But understanding the why is the second step in forgiveness — after naming your hurt. Because when you understand the why, you stop carrying their heavy thing on top of your heavy thing. They are still responsible for their own backpack. But you stop having to feel like you did something wrong."

Darius's arms were still crossed. But his eyebrows had unfurrowed a little.

Sammy looked, gently, in Darius's direction.

"Sometimes," said Sammy, "you are the one who is mad. Sometimes you come into a room with a heavy backpack and you do not even know why. You just know you want to be left alone. You just know you are mad at the world. That is also okay. That is also human. The thing to know — when YOU are the mad one — is that you are also carrying something. And maybe today is a day to figure out what it is."

Darius did not say anything during the lesson. He did not put his hand up. He did not participate.

But at the end of the day, when the other kids were getting their backpacks, Darius walked very quietly up to Ms. Calloway's desk. "Ms. Calloway?"

"Yes, Darius?"

"My dog died yesterday."

Ms. Calloway sat down in her chair so that she was at Darius's eye level. She did not say oh I am so sorry in a rush. She did not say that is terrible. She did not say anything at first. She just looked at him. "Darius," she said, "I am very sorry. That is a big thing. That is a really big thing."

"His name was Biscuit," said Darius. "He was thirteen."

"That is a long life for a dog. He had a lot of years with you."  
"I had him my whole life."

"Yes you did."

Darius's eyes filled with tears.

"I was so mad today," he said. "I did not know why I was mad. I was just mad. I was mad at everybody. I almost yelled at Sofia at lunch and she did not do anything."

"Darius," said Ms. Calloway, "that was your heavy thing. The mad was the heavy thing trying to come out sideways. Now that you know what it is — what it really is — you can tell people. You can say my dog died. You can let them be sad with you. You do not have to be mad alone." "Okay," said Darius. He wiped his eyes with the back of his hand. "Can I go now? My mom is waiting."

"Yes. I will see you tomorrow."

Darius left.

The next morning, Darius came in and walked straight up to Sofia. "Sofia," he said. "I was mad yesterday. Not at you. My dog died. I am sorry I was almost mean."

Sofia, who had not actually noticed Darius being almost-mean, because Sofia is six, said, "I am sorry about your dog. Was he a nice dog?" "He was the best dog."

"I am sorry."

They sat down together at the carpet.

This is what understanding the why does. It lets you walk up to somebody you almost hurt and tell them what you were

carrying. It lets the other person sit down with you. It turns I am mad at the world into I am sad about a real thing. And once you know the real thing, the mad part starts to lift, a little.

Darius's dog Biscuit is going to come back later. Biscuit's name is going to be on a small wooden cross in Darius's backyard for the rest of Darius's childhood. Biscuit is going to be the first thing Darius ever loved that died. It is going to matter to him for years.

But the night his dog died, Darius did not know what to do with the heavy thing. And the morning after, he came to school mad. And by the afternoon, somebody in a frog puppet had given him a name for the heavy thing, and a way to tell somebody else about it, and Darius — who is six years old and who has just lost his lifelong friend — is going to remember that for the rest of his life.